

Change Makers

Traders of a small town take a step towards saving both the planet and electricity bills by pushing CFLs



VIDISHA TRADERS UNITE FOR THEIR CAMPAIGN

By Ambreesh Mishra

Climate change, it seems, is impacting small Indian towns in unusual ways. Even as world leaders gathered at Copenhagen last year to find ways to cut carbon emissions, Vidisha in Madhya Pradesh was already doing its bit to save the planet. The traders' guild, Vidisha Vyapaar Mahasangh (VVM), held a camp recently to sell power-saving CFL lamps at a 35 per cent discount, instead of the usual power-guzzling filament incandescent lamps. Almost 4,500 CFL lamps worth Rs 4 lakh were sold during the two-day camp. Buoyed by the response, the VVM then held another camp in collaboration with the Vyapaar Mahasangh of the adjacent Ganj Basoda town. "This means fewer old filament bulbs and lower electricity use," says local MLA Vir Singh Raghuvanshi.

The traders' guilds are encouraging CFL makers and dealers to set up shop at these camps and offer discounts. The traders set up the camps, arrange publicity for CFLs and complement the discount offered by CFL-makers and dealers from their own funds. The move-

ment is the brainchild of VVM president Rajesh Jain, who hit upon the idea of promoting VVM lamps after the monthly power dues of his own grocery store more than halved from Rs 1,200 to Rs 500 per month when he replaced his old tube-lights and filament bulbs. "Earlier, traders used to donate to temples and build dharamshalas but we think tackling contemporary problems is a better way to contribute to society," he says.

Unlike some states which offer free replacement of filament bulbs with CFL lamps, the Madhya Pradesh Government has no subsidy component. Sanjay Shukla, the CMD of the Madhya Pradesh Central Region Power Distribution Company, says: "Such spontaneous initiatives from civil society have a far more enduring appeal and impact." The company now plans to join hands with other traders' bodies to promote the use of CFLs. And this is not all. The VVM now plans to promote the use of solar water heaters and cheaper air-cooling. Small town India, it seems, is fast becoming a vital part of the battle against global warming.